

Randomized Algorithms

Randomized 2-SAT and 3-SAT

Joseph Chuang-Chieh Lin

Department of Computer Science & Engineering
National Taiwan Ocean University

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Outline

- 1 SAT, local search, and Markov chains
- 2 Randomized 2-SAT
- 3 Naïve randomized 3-SAT
- 4 Restarted 3-SAT algorithm
- 5 Interpretation and teaching notes



Roadmap

- ▶ Start with SAT as a search problem on truth assignments.
- ▶ A simple randomized local-search algorithm for 2-SAT.
- ▶ Analyze its progress using a one-dimensional **random walk**.
- ▶ Reuse the same idea for 3-SAT, where the walk becomes biased in the wrong direction.
- ▶ Fix the issue with random restarts and get a faster-than-brute-force randomized algorithm.



Boolean formulas in CNF

Conjunctive Normal Form (CNF)

A **literal** is a variable x_i or its negation $\neg x_i$.

A **clause** is an OR (i.e., $\vee$) of literals.

A CNF formula is an AND of clauses.

$$x_1 \vee \neg x_2$$

 $\wedge$

$$\neg x_1 \vee x_3$$

 $\wedge$

$$x_2 \vee x_3$$

CNF formula: AND of clauses

k -SAT

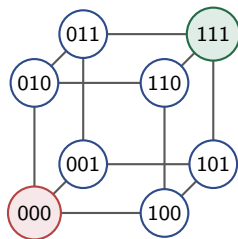
- ▶ In k -SAT, each clause has exactly k literals.
- ▶ 2-SAT: each clause has two literals.
- ▶ 3-SAT: each clause has three literals.
- ▶ General SAT is NP-hard; 3-SAT is NP-complete.
- ▶ 2-SAT is polynomial-time solvable, but the randomized analysis is useful because it introduces the Markov-chain method.

Example: a 2-SAT formula

$$(x_1 \vee x_2) \wedge (\neg x_1 \vee x_3) \wedge (\neg x_2 \vee \neg x_3)$$

Truth assignments as a hypercube

- ▶ A truth assignment is a bit string in $\{0, 1\}^n$.
- ▶ Flipping one variable moves to a neighboring vertex of the hypercube.
- ▶ Local search is a random walk on this assignment graph.



assignments form the n -dimensional hypercube

The local-search template

Randomized repair step

- ① If all clauses are satisfied, stop.
- ② Pick an unsatisfied clause.
- ③ Choose one literal in that clause uniformly at random.
- ④ Flip its variable.

- ▶ The clause becomes satisfied immediately after the flip.
- ▶ But other clauses **may become unsatisfied**.
- ▶ The analysis tracks progress toward **one fixed satisfying assignment S** .



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- ▶ But other clauses **may become unsatisfied**.
- ▶ The analysis tracks progress toward **one fixed satisfying assignment S** .
 - ▷ There could exist more than one satisfying assignment.

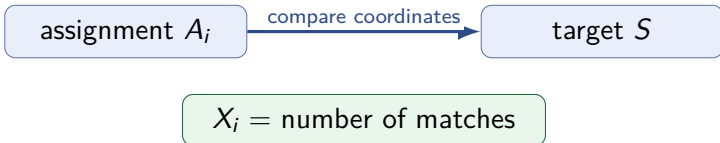


Why Markov chains enter

- ▶ The full assignment process has 2^n possible states.
- ▶ For the analysis, collapse the state to a single number:

$$X_i = \#\{\text{variables where current assignment } A_i \text{ agrees with } S\}.$$

- ▶ If $X_i = n$, the current assignment equals S and is satisfying.
- ▶ The key question becomes: **How long until this one-dimensional process hits n ?**



Example

► Let

$$F = (x_1 \vee \neg x_2) \wedge (\neg x_1 \vee x_3) \wedge (x_2 \vee x_3),$$

► Choose a satisfying assignment $S = (1, 1, 1)$.

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- Then A_i agrees with S only on x_2 , so $X_i = 1$.

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Randomized 2-SAT Algorithm

2-SAT Algorithm

- ① Start with an arbitrary truth assignment.
- ② Repeat up to $2mn^2$ times:
 - ① if all clauses are satisfied, stop;
 - ② choose an arbitrary unsatisfied clause;
 - ③ choose one of its two literals uniformly at random;
 - ④ flip the chosen variable.
- ③ If a satisfying assignment was found, return it.
- ④ Otherwise return “unsatisfiable.”

Example: one repair step

$$\phi = (x_1 \vee x_2) \wedge (\bar{x}_1 \vee x_3) \wedge (\bar{x}_2 \vee \bar{x}_3)$$

$x_1 \vee x_2$: false



flip x_1 or flip x_2

$\neg x_1 \vee x_3$: true

$\neg x_2 \vee \neg x_3$: true

- ▶ Suppose $A = (x_1, x_2, x_3) = (0, 0, 1)$.
- ▶ Clause $(x_1 \vee x_2)$ is unsatisfied.
- ▶ The algorithm flips either x_1 or x_2 , each with probability $1/2$.

Fix a satisfying assignment

- ▶ Assume the formula is satisfiable.
- ▶ Fix one satisfying assignment S .
- ▶ Let A_i be the current assignment after i flips.
- ▶ Let $X_i = \#\{\ell : A_i(x_\ell) = S(x_\ell)\}$.
- ▶ Reaching $X_i = n$ is sufficient for success.

Observation (Worst Case)

*The algorithm may find another satisfying assignment before $X_i = n$; ignoring this only makes the analysis **pessimistic**.*



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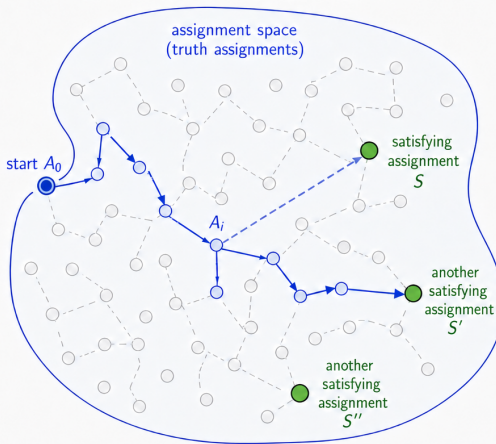
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$$\{A_i = S\} \subseteq \{A_i \text{ is satisfying}\}.$$



Randomized local search for SAT with multiple satisfying assignments

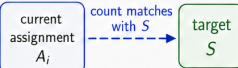


Reality: the random walk may hit any satisfying assignment.

● There may be many successful endpoints ($S, S', S'', \dots$).

Analysis: fix one satisfying assignment S and track

X_i = number of variables where A_i agrees with S .



$$X_i = \# \{j : A_i(j) = S(j)\}$$

Why an unsatisfied clause helps

Key logic

Suppose clause C is unsatisfied by A_i , but S satisfies C .

- ▶ Since A_i makes every literal in C false, but S makes at least one literal in C true.
- ▶ A_i and S must disagree on at least one variable appearing in C .
- ▶ For a 2-SAT clause, there are only two variables.
- ▶ Therefore, a uniformly random flip among the two literals improves X_i with probability $\geq 1/2$.

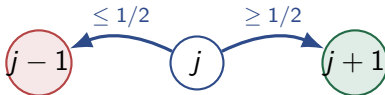
Transition inequalities for 2-SAT

For $1 \leq j \leq n - 1$,

$$\Pr[X_{i+1} = j + 1 \mid X_i = j] \geq \frac{1}{2},$$

and

$$\Pr[X_{i+1} = j - 1 \mid X_i = j] \leq \frac{1}{2}.$$



A pessimistic Markov chain

The process X_i is not necessarily Markovian: the probability of improvement can depend on the detailed current assignment.

Pessimistic comparison chain Y_i

$$Y_0 = X_0, \quad \Pr[Y_{i+1} = 1 \mid Y_i = 0] = 1,$$

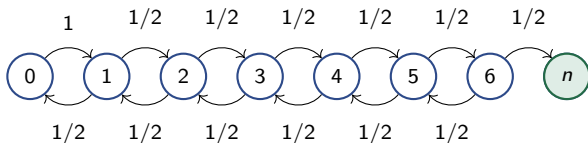
and for $1 \leq j \leq n-1$,

$$\Pr[Y_{i+1} = j+1 \mid Y_i = j] = \frac{1}{2}, \quad \Pr[Y_{i+1} = j-1 \mid Y_i = j] = \frac{1}{2}.$$

- ▶ Y_i is no more favorable than X_i .
- ▶ Its hitting time of n **upper-bounds** the expected time for the algorithm.



The random-walk picture for 2-SAT



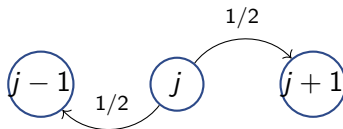
state j = number of variables matching a fixed satisfying assignment S

- ▶ This is a simple random walk on $\{0, 1, \dots, n\}$.
- ▶ State n is the target: the current assignment equals S .
- ▶ State 0 deterministically moves to 1.

Hitting-time notation

h_j : the expected number of steps for Y_i to reach n , starting from $Y_0 = j$.

- ▶ $h_n = 0$.
- ▶ $h_0 = h_1 + 1$ because state 0 always moves to 1.
- ▶ For $1 \leq j \leq n-1$, condition on the next step.



Hitting-time equations for 2-SAT

System of equations

$$h_n = 0,$$

$$h_j = \frac{h_{j-1}}{2} + \frac{h_{j+1}}{2} + 1, \quad 1 \leq j \leq n-1,$$

$$h_0 = h_1 + 1.$$

- ▶ The $+1$ accounts for the step just taken.
- ▶ The average accounts for the two equally likely next states.
- ▶ These equations have a unique solution.



Solving the equations: finite differences

Claim

For $0 \leq j \leq n-1$,

$$h_j = h_{j+1} + 2j + 1.$$

- ▶ At $j = 0$, this is $h_0 = h_1 + 1$.
- ▶ The recurrence implies

$$h_{j+1} = 2h_j - h_{j-1} - 2.$$

- ▶ If $h_{j-1} = h_j + 2(j-1) + 1$, then

$$h_{j+1} = h_j - 2j - 1.$$

Expected hitting time for 2-SAT

Summing the finite differences gives

$$h_0 = h_1 + 1 = h_2 + 1 + 3 = \cdots = \sum_{i=0}^{n-1} (2i + 1) = n^2.$$

Equivalently, the solution is

$$h_j = n^2 - j^2.$$

From any starting assignment, the expected number of repair steps until matching S is at most n^2 .

Lemma 1

- ▶ Assume a 2-SAT formula with n variables has a satisfying assignment and the algorithm is allowed to run until it finds one.
- ▶ Then the expected number of steps until the algorithm finds a satisfying assignment is **at most n^2** .



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- ▶ The proof analyzes the pessimistic chain Y_i .
 - ▶ The real algorithm can only do better, because an unsatisfied 2-clause offers an improving flip with probability at least $1/2$.



From expectation to high-probability success

- ▶ Lemma 1 gives an expected hitting time of at most n^2 .
- ▶ To avoid running forever, the algorithm uses m segments of length $2n^2$.
- ▶ In any segment, regardless of where it starts, let Z be the time to find a satisfying assignment.

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By Markov's inequality,

$$\Pr[Z > 2n^2] \leq \frac{\mathbb{E}[Z]}{2n^2} \leq \frac{n^2}{2n^2} = \frac{1}{2}.$$



One-sided error

Theorem 1

The 2-SAT algorithm always returns a correct answer if the formula is unsatisfiable. If the formula is satisfiable, then with probability at least

$$1 - 2^{-m}$$

it returns a satisfying assignment.

- If it returns an assignment, the assignment is checked and correct.

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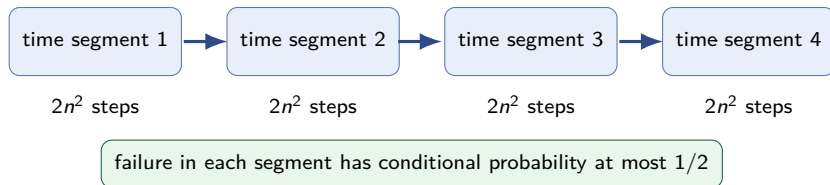
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- ▶ If it returns an assignment, the assignment is checked and correct.
- ▶ If it says “unsatisfiable,” it may be wrong only when
 - ▷ the formula was satisfiable but
 - ▷ the random walk did not find a solution in time.



Why the failure probability is 2^{-m}



Therefore,

$$\Pr[\text{fail in all } m \text{ segments}] \leq \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^m.$$

Runtime accounting for 2-SAT

- ▶ Number of repair steps: $2mn^2$.
- ▶ A naïve implementation may scan for an unsatisfied clause in $O(n^2)$ time, since there are $O(n^2)$ distinct 2-clauses. (WHY?)



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$$2^{-m} \leq \epsilon \Rightarrow m \geq \lg(1/\epsilon).$$



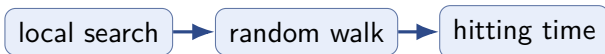
Takeaways from 2-SAT

- 1 A local search algorithm can be analyzed by tracking *distance* to one fixed solution.
- 2 The algorithm requires

$$\mathbb{E}[\text{remaining time to success} \mid A] \leq n^2,$$

for each current assignment A .

- 3 It is enough to dominate it by a simpler pessimistic Markov chain.
- 4 Expected hitting time plus Markov's inequality gives a Monte Carlo algorithm with tunable one-sided error.



Moving from 2-SAT to 3-SAT

- ▶ The same repair step applies to 3-SAT: choose an unsatisfied clause and flip one of its literals uniformly at random.
- ▶ But an unsatisfied 3-clause may have only one variable on which A_i and S disagree.
- ▶ Therefore the probability of improving the match count is **only guaranteed to be at least $1/3$** .  orz

Key change/issue

improvement probability: $\frac{1}{2} \longrightarrow \frac{1}{3}$.



A Naïve Randomized 3-SAT

3-SAT Algorithm

- ① Start with an arbitrary truth assignment.
- ② Repeat up to m times:
 - ① if all clauses are satisfied, stop;
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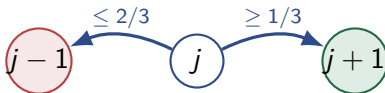
Transition inequalities for 3-SAT

Again fix a satisfying assignment S and let X_i be the number of matches with S . For $1 \leq j \leq n-1$,

$$\Pr[X_{i+1} = j+1 \mid X_i = j] \geq \frac{1}{3},$$

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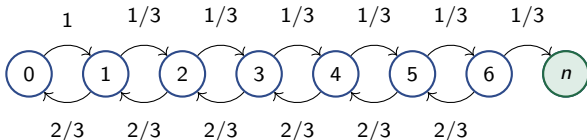
Pessimistic chain for 3-SAT

Define $Y_0 = X_0$ and

$$\Pr[Y_{i+1} = 1 \mid Y_i = 0] = 1,$$

while for $1 \leq j \leq n - 1$,

$$\Pr[Y_{i+1} = j + 1 \mid Y_i = j] = \frac{1}{3}, \quad \Pr[Y_{i+1} = j - 1 \mid Y_i = j] = \frac{2}{3}.$$



state j = number of variables matching a fixed satisfying assignment S

The drift is now unfavorable

- ▶ In 2-SAT, the pessimistic walk was unbiased.
- ▶ In 3-SAT, the pessimistic walk moves away from n with probability $2/3$.
- ▶ The target n is uphill against the drift.



Hitting-time equations for 3-SAT

Let h_j be the expected time to hit n from state j in the pessimistic chain.

Equations

$$h_n = 0,$$

$$h_j = \frac{2h_{j-1}}{3} + \frac{h_{j+1}}{3} + 1, \quad 1 \leq j \leq n-1,$$

$$h_0 = h_1 + 1.$$

- ▶ Same first-step analysis as before.
- ▶ Different probabilities change the solution dramatically.



Solution of the 3-SAT recurrence

The solution is

$$h_j = 2^{n+2} - 2^{j+2} - 3(n - j).$$

Equivalently, one can prove by induction that

$$h_j = h_{j+1} + 2^{j+2} - 3.$$

Consequence

Starting from a poor assignment, the expected time can be

$$\Theta(2^n).$$



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Method	Main cost	Comment
Brute force	2^n assignments	deterministic exhaustive search
Basic local search	$\Theta(2^n)$ flips	not compelling

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Method	Main cost	Comment
Brute force	2^n assignments	deterministic exhaustive search
Basic local search	$\Theta(2^n)$ flips	not compelling
Restarted local search	$O(n^{3/2}(4/3)^n)$ flips	faster exponential



Two key observations for improving 3-SAT

- 1 A **uniformly random initial assignment** has about $n/2$ matches with S on average.
- 2 With exponentially small but useful probability, it starts **much closer to S** .
- 3 Once the walk starts, the pessimistic drift points away from S .
- 4 Therefore: use many **short random starts** instead of one long run.



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Design principle

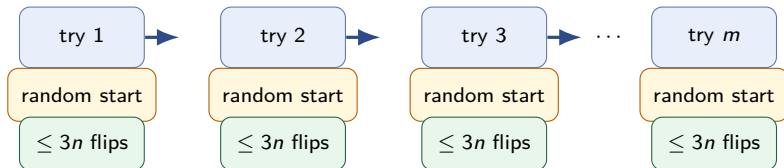
Restart before the biased walk has **too much time to drift away** from the solution.



Revised Randomized 3-SAT

Modified 3-SAT Algorithm

- ① Repeat up to m times:
 - ① choose a random truth assignment;
 - ② run at most $3n$ repair steps;
 - ③ stop early if a satisfying assignment is found.
- ② Otherwise return “unsatisfiable.”



restart rather than spend too long in a biased-down random walk

Random initial assignment

Fix a satisfying assignment S .

- ▶ Choose A_0 uniformly from $\{0, 1\}^n$.
- ▶ The number of mismatches with S is

$$J \sim \text{Bin}(n, 1/2).$$

- ▶ Hence

$$\Pr[J = j] = \binom{n}{j} 2^{-n}.$$

Success probability from j mismatches

Let q_j be a lower bound on the probability that one restarted trial reaches S within $3n$ flips, starting from exactly j mismatches.

- ▶ A good flip decreases the mismatch count by 1.
- ▶ A bad flip increases it by 1.



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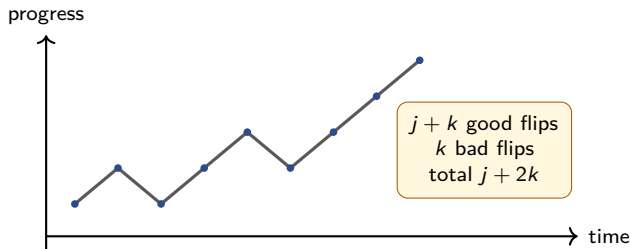
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- ▶ A good flip decreases the mismatch count by 1.
- ▶ A bad flip increases it by 1.
- ▶ Good flip probability is at least $1/3$.
- ▶ Bad flip probability is at most $2/3$.

We lower-bound success by counting one favorable type of path to S .



Counting a favorable path



Suppose the path uses:

- ▶ $j + k$ good flips, probability factor $(1/3)^{j+k}$;
- ▶ k bad flips, probability factor $(2/3)^k$.

The net improvement is $(j + k) - k = j$, enough to remove j mismatches.



Lower bound for q_j

If the walk has k bad flips and $j + k$ good flips, the total length is $j + 2k$.

The number of orders is

$$\binom{j+2k}{k}.$$

Therefore,

$$q_j \geq \max_{k=0,1,\dots,j} \binom{j+2k}{k} \left(\frac{2}{3}\right)^k \left(\frac{1}{3}\right)^{j+k}.$$

► Restricting to $k \leq j$ ensures $j + 2k \leq 3j \leq 3n$.



Choose the simple case $k = j$

Taking $k = j$ gives a valid path length $3j \leq 3n$:

$$q_j \geq \binom{3j}{j} \left(\frac{2}{3}\right)^j \left(\frac{1}{3}\right)^{2j}.$$

Why this is useful

The binomial coefficient counts many possible successful orders, not just one path.



Stirling's formula

Lemma (Stirling, loose form)

For $m > 0$,

$$m! = \sqrt{2\pi m} \left(\frac{m}{e}\right)^m (1 \pm o(1)).$$

In particular,

$$\sqrt{2\pi m} \left(\frac{m}{e}\right)^m \leq m! \leq 2\sqrt{2\pi m} \left(\frac{m}{e}\right)^m.$$

► We use it only to lower-bound $\binom{3j}{j}$.



Lower-bounding the binomial coefficient

For a constant $c > 0$,

$$\binom{3j}{j} = \frac{(3j)!}{j!(2j)!} \geq \frac{c}{\sqrt{j}} \left(\frac{27}{4}\right)^j.$$

Therefore,

$$\begin{aligned} q_j &\geq \frac{c}{\sqrt{j}} \left(\frac{27}{4}\right)^j \left(\frac{2}{3}\right)^j \left(\frac{1}{3}\right)^{2j} \\ &= \frac{c}{\sqrt{j}} \cdot \frac{1}{2^j}. \end{aligned}$$

► Also $q_0 = 1$.



Average over the random start

Let q be the success probability of one restarted trial.

$$\begin{aligned} q &\geq \sum_{j=0}^n \Pr(J = j) q_j \\ &\geq 2^{-n} + \sum_{j=1}^n \binom{n}{j} 2^{-n} \frac{c}{\sqrt{j} 2^j}. \end{aligned}$$

Since $j \leq n$,

$$\frac{1}{\sqrt{j}} \geq \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}}.$$

Hence

$$q \geq \frac{c}{\sqrt{n}} \sum_{j=0}^n \binom{n}{j} 2^{-n} 2^{-j}.$$



The binomial theorem step

Continue from

$$q \geq \frac{c}{\sqrt{n}} \sum_{j=0}^n \binom{n}{j} 2^{-n} 2^{-j}.$$

Then

$$\begin{aligned} q &\geq \frac{c}{\sqrt{n}} \frac{1}{2^n} \sum_{j=0}^n \binom{n}{j} \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^j (1)^{n-j} \\ &= \frac{c}{\sqrt{n}} \frac{1}{2^n} \left(1 + \frac{1}{2}\right)^n \\ &= \frac{c}{\sqrt{n}} \left(\frac{3}{4}\right)^n. \end{aligned}$$

Expected number of restarts & repair steps

Each restarted trial succeeds with probability at least

$$q \geq \frac{c}{\sqrt{n}} \left(\frac{3}{4}\right)^n.$$

The number of trials until success is **geometric** with mean at most

$$\frac{1}{q} = O\left(\sqrt{n} \left(\frac{4}{3}\right)^n\right).$$

Each trial runs at most $3n$ repair steps, so the expected number of repair steps is

$$O\left(n^{3/2} \left(\frac{4}{3}\right)^n\right).$$



Monte Carlo version for 3-SAT

- ▶ If the formula is unsatisfiable, the algorithm never returns a false assignment.
- ▶ If it returns an assignment, the assignment is checked and is correct.
- ▶ The only error is declaring “unsatisfiable” after not finding a solution.

Amplification idea

If the expected time to find a satisfying assignment is at most a , then using b independent blocks of length $2a$ gives failure probability at most 2^{-b} .



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- ▶ $2a \Rightarrow \frac{1}{2}$ by Markov's inequality; $a := 3n/q$
- ▶ independent b blocks $\Rightarrow$ error prob. $< \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^b$.



Why restarts help

Long single run

- ▶ starts somewhere;
- ▶ biased walk tends to lose matches;
- ▶ many steps may be wasted.

Many short runs

- ▶ samples many random starting points;
- ▶ occasionally starts close to S ;
- ▶ gives each promising start a short chance.

Intuitive idea

Random restarts trade one long biased walk for many independent chances to start close to S .



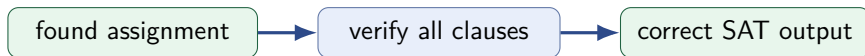
Comparison with brute force

Algorithm	Expected / worst-case scale	One-sided error?
brute-force	2^n assignments	<i>no</i> (always correct)
basic 3-SAT local search	$\Theta(2^n)$ steps	yes, if stopped early
restarted 3-SAT local search	$O(n^{3/2}(4/3)^n)$ steps	yes

- ▶ The base improves from 2 to $4/3$.
- ▶ The algorithm is still exponential, consistent with NP-completeness of 3-SAT.



One-sided error in both algorithms



possible error: formula is satisfiable, but search timed out

- ▶ The algorithms never output an invalid satisfying assignment.
- ▶ Stopping early converts Las Vegas-style search into a Monte Carlo decision procedure.

Why arbitrary unsatisfied clause selection is okay

- ▶ The algorithm may choose any currently unsatisfied clause.
- ▶ The analysis does not require a random clause.
- ▶ The only property needed is:
an unsatisfied clause under A_i is satisfied by S , so at least one of its variables disagrees with S .
- ▶ Randomness is used only in choosing which literal to flip.

Robustness

Even adversarial clause choice preserves the lower bound $1/k$ on an improving flip.



The exact process versus the comparison chain

Actual process X_i

- ▶ depends on formula structure;
- ▶ depends on current assignment;
- ▶ may not be Markovian as a scalar process.

Comparison chain Y_i

- ▶ one-dimensional;
- ▶ Markovian;
- ▶ pessimistic enough for upper bounds.



analyze Y_i to bound the algorithm

Why the cutoff $3n$ appears for restarted 3-SAT

- ▶ If the start has j mismatches, the counted favorable path uses j bad flips and $2j$ good flips.
- ▶ Total length: $3j$.
- ▶ Since $j \leq n$, this is at most $3n$.

The $3n$ cutoff is chosen to support a clean combinatorial lower bound on success probability, not because it is an exact optimal runtime.



Constants versus asymptotics

- ▶ The proof keeps constants such as $3n$ and $c/\sqrt{n}$ to make the analysis explicit.
- ▶ The main asymptotic message is the exponential base:

$$O\left(n^{3/2} \left(\frac{4}{3}\right)^n\right).$$

- ▶ Polynomial factors are less important than reducing the base from 2 to $4/3$.



An example for discussion

Consider

$$\phi = (x_1 \vee x_2 \vee x_3) \wedge (\neg x_1 \vee x_2 \vee \neg x_3) \wedge (x_1 \vee \neg x_2 \vee x_3).$$

Let

$$S = (x_1, x_2, x_3) = (1, 1, 1).$$

Question

If the current assignment is $A = (0, 1, 0)$ and an unsatisfied clause is chosen, how many variables in that clause must disagree with S ?

- ▶ At least one. That is all the general analysis needs.

Summary

- ▶ 2-SAT local search is controlled by an unbiased random walk on $\{0, \dots, n\}$.
- ▶ Its expected hitting time is at most n^2 .
- ▶ 3-SAT local search gives a biased walk with success direction probability only $1/3$.
- ▶ Long runs are inefficient, so random restarts are essential.
- ▶ The modified 3-SAT algorithm has expected search length

$$O\left(n^{3/2} \left(\frac{4}{3}\right)^n\right).$$

Discussion questions

- 1 Why is tracking matches with a fixed satisfying assignment legitimate even though the algorithm does not know S ?
- 2 In the 2-SAT proof, which step fails if clauses had three literals?
- 3 Why do restarts improve 3-SAT but are unnecessary for the polynomial 2-SAT bound?
- 4 What is the exact role of Markov's inequality in converting expected time into bounded-error decision algorithms?
- 5 Could different restart lengths improve constants or polynomial factors?

Discussions

